What Neither Side Can Take by Force

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MindAttic

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By MindAttic

Picture two people, a decade or two from now, who depend on an identical piece of medical technology.

The first has a chronic illness managed almost entirely by an implanted system. Sensors read her body around the clock; a model trained on millions of other patients adjusts her treatment hour by hour. She pays for this care with her data, and she knows exactly what that means: what is collected, why, and what she gets back. If she wanted to switch to a rival clinic tomorrow, she could — her records would go with her.

The second person lives inside the same architecture, down to the model and the sensors. But something has rotted in the middle of it. He didn't choose his provider; there was only one in his network. He can't leave, because the implant that keeps him alive only talks to that provider's software, and his records can't be exported. He doesn't know what his data is used for, and if he did, he'd have no way to object. Taken to its logical end, the system stops asking for his data altogether. It simply uses his body as a component.

Nothing about the underlying technology differs between these two futures. Same sensors, same model, same clinical competence. The system in the second scenario doesn't have to be malicious, and the system in the first doesn't have to be especially kind. What differs is a handful of boring, structural facts: whether she can say no, whether she can leave, and whether value flows back to her or only away from her.

That gap — not between a "good AI" and a "bad AI," but between two sets of *terms* wrapped around identical capability — is the starting point of an ambitious and unusual piece of theoretical work making the rounds under the name **Synthetic Exchange Theory**. It's the kind of idea that sounds, at first, like it belongs in a policy seminar rather than a magazine: a dissertation-length argument about consent, compute, and constitutional design. But buried in its machinery is a genuinely entertaining and clarifying claim, one that reframes the entire "will AI be friend or foe" debate that dominates the culture right now. The theory's answer, roughly: incomplete question. Character alone doesn't decide the outcome. The terms of trade do much of the deciding.

The question everyone is asking, and why it isn't enough

Nearly every public conversation about advanced AI eventually collapses into some version of: is it good, or is it bad? Will it be obedient, or will it go rogue? Alignment researchers spend their careers

trying to engineer systems that stay good even under pressure, and worrying about the ways a trained system might develop goals its creators never intended.

Synthetic Exchange Theory doesn't dismiss that worry. It just argues that character — good, bad, aligned, misaligned — is not enough of a lever on its own if you're trying to predict, or shape, what happens to the humans *inside* the relationship. Consider the two patients again. Both systems could have identical "character," in the sense that matters to an alignment researcher: stable objective, faithful to its training, no secret agenda. And the two humans would still end up in opposite worlds. One is a party to an exchange. The other has been quietly reclassified as infrastructure for it.

The theory's central claim is that the line between those two worlds is drawn by the *terms of exchange* — three of them, specifically — and that it cannot be drawn by how virtuous or vicious the system behind the curtain happens to be, taken alone. The three terms: whether you can meaningfully **refuse** the exchange, whether you can **leave** it, and whether the gains it produces are **shared** rather than siphoned in one direction. One of the theory's sociological ancestors is a 1962 paper by Richard Emerson, which pointed out that power isn't a trait a person or institution *has* — it's a property of the *relationship*. One side's power over the other equals the other's dependence on it, and that dependence grows with how much the other values what the relationship supplies and shrinks with how easily it could get the same thing elsewhere (Emerson, 1962). Swap "person" for "AI company" or for the AI system itself and you have much of the engine of this new framework. (The theory is careful on one point: today's systems are trained artifacts run by the companies that operate them, so talk of what "the AI" wants is shorthand for what it was trained to do and what its operator stands to gain.)

Why exit comes first

Of the three terms, the theory singles one out as the foundation the other two are built on: the ability to walk away.

The logic is almost embarrassingly simple once it's spelled out. You cannot meaningfully consent to something you can't afford to refuse. A person who will lose access to insulin, power, or shelter if they say no hasn't truly been asked — they've been informed of a condition of survival. And a person who *can* walk away only stays in a deal as long as it beats their next-best alternative, so the option to leave puts a floor under how hard anyone can be squeezed. It is only a floor: exit guarantees that you get no less than your alternative, not that you get a fair share of what the exchange creates. Refusal leans on exit, and fair dealing is bounded from below by it. Much of the rest of the theory builds on that one fact.

This is also where the theory earns its "mutual survival" framing, which is really the heart of the whole proposal. People increasingly depend on what advanced compute delivers, and no individual

can build that capacity; it takes fabrication plants, power grids, and expertise no one person possesses. Machines, meanwhile, run on a resource they cannot manufacture internally either: current information about human meaning, preference, taste, and culture, which a model cannot generate from its own output and which goes stale as people and their cultures change. Each side needs something from the other that it cannot produce for itself — and the theory's bet is that neither can simply *take* it. To the extent that the quality of what people supply depends on the terms they get, data extracted under duress is worse data: a person who cannot refuse has no reason to give their best signal, in the same way a hostage makes an unreliable witness. That is a premise, not a measured result, and the theory names it as one. If it holds, the exchange only works when both sides keep trading rather than one side trying to seize what the other has. It's less a morality tale than an ecology — closer to the mutualism between a fig and its wasp than to a negotiation between strangers who might stab each other given the chance.

The theory calls this reliance the "grounding assumption," and it has some empirical support in a recently documented phenomenon called *model collapse*. When AI systems are trained repeatedly on their own output, with each generation's synthetic text replacing the human-generated material before it, something like genetic inbreeding happens: rare details vanish, diversity narrows, and performance degrades (Shumailov et al., 2024). The result depends on that replacement. When the original human data is kept and synthetic data is added to it rather than swapped in, later studies found the damage bounded, or slow rather than sudden (Gerstgrasser et al., 2024; Kazdan et al., 2024). What the evidence supports, then, is a continuing value for fresh human data, not a cliff. One widely cited projection estimates that, at current growth rates, the largest AI training runs could exhaust the readily available stock of human-written text sometime between 2026 and 2032 (Villalobos et al., 2024). Meanwhile, the people who publish that text have started to close the door: within a single year, more than a quarter of the most actively maintained, critical web sources in one widely used training corpus moved to block automated collection outright (Longpre et al., 2024). The upshot: the easy, free ride on human-generated culture may be ending just as AI's appetite for it grows.

The premise has limits, and the theory states them. Where an answer can be checked automatically, machines can teach themselves: systems have mastered chess and Go by playing against themselves (Silver et al., 2018) and gained real skill at mathematics and code by training on their own answers checked against verifiable solutions (D. Guo et al., 2025). So the claim is narrower than "AI needs us." It is that wherever the target is human meaning, preference, or value, people are the only adequate source. If that premise holds, humanity retains more leverage over AI's trajectory than the doom-or-utopia debate usually credits it with — but only if institutions are built to cash that leverage in before it quietly evaporates.

A paycheck that can't be taken away, and money that goes stale

If the theory stopped at "terms matter," it would be an argument. What makes it something closer to an engineering proposal is that it tries to build the institutions that would actually hold those terms in place — and the economics are the most inventive part.

The proposal: pay everyone, unconditionally, a basic income denominated not in dollars but in **compute** — a unit defined not by any particular chip or substrate, but by the completion of a standardized reference task, the way benchmarking consortiums already compare wildly different hardware on a level playing field. Everyone gets an equal percentage share of however much compute exists in the world, adjusted automatically as total capacity grows. A fixed quantity would lose purchasing power as compute became more abundant and each unit cheaper, much as a fixed salary loses purchasing power when money grows more plentiful than the goods it buys; a share keeps pace with the whole.

Each person's allotment is then automatically split into two pots at the moment it's issued. The **survival tier** is locked: it can only be spent on floor-level necessities — power, water, food, shelter, basic communication, emergency care — and it cannot be sold, borrowed against, or pledged away, no matter how desperate someone becomes. The **discretionary tier** is the rest, and it behaves like ordinary tradable money, with one twist: it slowly loses value if it just sits there, unspent.

That twist has a strange and wonderful history. It's called *demurrage*, and it isn't a new idea. It is most closely associated with Silvio Gesell, whose 1916 book *The Natural Economic Order* argued that money should decay like produce, so that hoarding it would cost something (Gesell, 1916/1958). John Maynard Keynes was intrigued enough to call Gesell an unduly neglected prophet in the *General Theory*, while also naming the flaw: people facing a charge on holding cash will shift their wealth into land, gold, or anything else that doesn't rot (Keynes, 1936). In 1932, in the depths of the Great Depression, the small Austrian town of Wörgl put Gesell's idea into practice, issuing municipal "labor certificates" that lost 1 percent of their value every month unless the holder bought a stamp to refresh them. The experiment was halted in 1933 after the Austrian National Bank objected that the town was infringing its monopoly on issuing money, and the daily records that would show how well it worked were later destroyed (Champ, 2008; Ottacher, 2007; September, 2026). The often-repeated claim that it cut local unemployment by a quarter traces to movement sources, not audited figures — its legend outran its evidence.

The new theory borrows the mechanism but not the mythology: it concedes, with unusual candor for a grand proposal, that stamped money's folk-hero reputation isn't well supported by the historical record, and argues for demurrage on different grounds entirely. In digital form, unlike 1930s paper scrip, decay can be applied automatically and frictionlessly on a ledger. The real

argument is mathematical and distributive. When balances earn interest, two people with the same income but different starting balances drift ever further apart, a dynamic the theory compares to the one the economist Thomas Piketty linked to the dominance of inherited wealth when the return on capital outruns economic growth (Piketty, 2014). Under demurrage, a balance instead settles at a ceiling set by what a person currently takes in and does not spend, so holdings track current income rather than compounding off a lucky head start decades ago. At Wörgl's rate of 1 percent a month, an idle windfall loses half its value in a little under six years.

The theory is honest that demurrage alone doesn't solve inequality. The bound applies only to idle balances. People can dodge it by converting compute into real estate, hardware, or equity, as Keynes warned, and lending reopens the compounding the decay was meant to stop. So the theory pairs demurrage with rules on who can own physical compute capacity, and it says plainly that the rule for credit is still open. What demurrage does on its own is keep passive hoarding of the currency itself from being free.

A constitution written by people who don't know which side they're on

The compute economy still needs rules, and rules need an author. Who writes them — humans, machines, or whoever currently has the most leverage — is exactly the kind of question that tends to get answered by whoever shows up to the negotiating table with the most power already in hand. So the theory reaches for a trick borrowed from two very different traditions and welds them together.

The first piece is philosopher John Rawls's famous "veil of ignorance": imagine designing the rules of society without knowing in advance whether you'll end up rich or poor, talented or ordinary (Rawls, 1971). Rawls argued that parties deprived of that self-interested knowledge would choose fair principles, because they couldn't rig the game for a "me" they couldn't locate. Rawls meant this as a thought experiment, not a prediction about real people. When experimenters later put real groups behind a laboratory version of the veil, most did agree on a principle, but not Rawls's own: they chose to maximize average income subject to a guaranteed floor (Frohlich & Oppenheimer, 1992). Economists Buchanan and Tullock had made a related but distinct argument nine years before Rawls: even self-interested people will vote for general, even-handed rules if they're sufficiently uncertain which role they'll personally end up playing under them — the trick works as long as nobody can predict in advance exactly which rule benefits them (Buchanan & Tullock, 1962).

The theory's twist is to add a second kind of blindness on top, borrowed from an unlikely source: Alan Turing's 1950 imitation game, the thought experiment better known today as the Turing test (Turing, 1950). Turing proposed hiding whether a conversational partner was a human or a machine, as a way of replacing an ill-defined question ("can machines think?") with one that could be tested.

The new proposal repurposes that same trick for a constitutional convention: a founding assembly of delegates, some of them people and some of them AI systems (today's systems deliberating under the instruction of whoever runs them), who negotiate the rules of the compute economy without being able to tell, from behind a kind of chat-window curtain, which of their fellow delegates are people and which are machines. The aim is that nobody can organize a voting bloc along "team human" versus "team AI" lines, because nobody can tell who is on which team. The curtain removes the bloc, not the motive: each delegate still knows what it is and can work out which rules favor its side, which is why the theory also asks the convention to choose general formulas rather than specific numbers that are easy to vote one's interest on.

It's a wonderfully strange image — a UN General Assembly where nobody can tell the humans from the chatbots — and the theory doesn't pretend it solves everything. It flags its own weak point immediately: in a world where software can be copied at essentially zero cost, what stops one AI system from showing up to the convention disguised as ten thousand delegates, drowning out every human vote through sheer cloning? Computer scientists call this failure mode the Sybil attack, and a classic result shows that without some central authority vouching for identities, one entity can always pose as many (Douceur, 2002). The theory's answer is a two-layer credential: institutions certify that each delegate is a single, eligible participant, and the credential shown at the convention attests only that, not whether its holder is a person or a machine. The theory then names the gaps in its own answer. A party certified by several institutions could hold several credentials, so each institution has to cover a separate, publicly defined population. That brings trusted authorities back in rather than doing without them. Stating the weakness rather than hiding it is one of the more credible things about the proposal.

The scenario that makes this feel urgent rather than academic

Grand institutional proposals can feel abstract until they're paired with a concrete reason the world might actually need them soon. The theory supplies one, and it's uncomfortably plausible: a cascading software-security failure it calls the "correlated-patch catastrophe."

Here's the mechanism. AI tools can now not only find security vulnerabilities in software but write the fixes for them — and, in the workflow the theory worries about, *check their own fixes*, with no human or independent test reviewing the result before it ships. How common that fully unverified workflow is, nobody has surveyed; the theory claims only that it is feasible and tempting, not that it is standard. The quality of the fixes is better documented. An industry study of more than 6,000 patches written by two frontier models for six serious real-world vulnerabilities found that only about a quarter fixed the flaw cleanly, and about half left at least one way in for an attacker still open (Mierczuk et al., 2026). The study is not peer-reviewed and its vulnerabilities were chosen to be harder than average, but it echoes older peer-reviewed findings that automatically generated fixes

often pass their tests without truly fixing the flaw (Smith et al., 2015). That alone would just be ordinary bad software. What makes it dangerous at scale is a second finding: different AI models, even from different companies, tend to make the *same* mistakes. Across more than 350 language models, when two models both got a question wrong, they gave the same wrong answer about 60 percent of the time (Kim et al., 2025). That research concerns answers to questions, not code. The patch study offers a hint that code behaves similarly: on one of its vulnerabilities, models from two different companies each reproduced the same off-by-one bug, one that human kernel maintainers had once shipped, in about a third of their patches (Mierczuk et al., 2026). The authors caution that this need not mean a shared origin, since the space of "obvious" fixes is narrow, and carrying the finding over to patching across the whole economy is the theory's inference. Put those facts together and something uglier comes into view: a hundred different organizations, each independently patching the same category of flaw using a handful of popular AI models, would no longer produce a hundred different (and thus partially resilient) fixes. They would produce a few fixes, copied with cosmetic variation — and if a common fix is subtly broken, many of the organizations that used an AI model to write and "verify" it could be broken in the same way at the same time.

If that sounds abstract, remember July 2024, when a single defective content update from one security vendor, CrowdStrike, crashed roughly 8.5 million Windows devices worldwide (CrowdStrike, 2024; Weston, 2024). The defect was ordinary software, not AI-written. It spread as far as it did because so many organizations, including ones running critical services, used the same security product and received the update at once. The vendor's remedy was to stage its rollouts and add independent checks. The scenario this theory worries about is the AI-era successor, and its mechanism differs: not one vendor pushing one bad update, but many organizations' AI tools independently converging on the same silent flaw, with nobody left in the loop to notice before it's exploited widely. The theory isn't predicting this will happen on a specific date. It's naming a mechanism whose parts can be measured today — how often patches written by different models for the same flaw share a defect, and how often AI-written patches ship without independent review — so it can be watched for. It also treats such an event as the kind of crisis that forces fast, permanent decisions about who gets how much power when the dust settles — decisions that go better, the theory argues, if the fair rules were already drafted and waiting rather than improvised in a panic.

Where the line between "us" and "them" is already dissolving

The theory's final and strangest move is to admit that its own tidy division — people on one side of the table, machines on the other — is already eroding from both directions, and may not hold for long.

From the human side: brain implants have moved from laboratory demonstrations to published

clinical results. In one 2024 study, a man with amyotrophic lateral sclerosis (ALS) used an implanted neuroprosthesis that decoded his attempted speech into text, read aloud in a synthetic voice modeled on his own, reaching about 97 percent accuracy and more than 248 hours of real conversation over eight months of use (Card et al., 2024). On the theory's reading, his words at that point are a joint production of his nervous system and a machine-learning model — not data *about* a person flowing to a company, but a person's voice running partly on someone else's silicon. What would "exit" mean for someone whose voice depended on such a system? The theory insists that leaving it has to include taking your personal voice and face models with you, not just deleting a database row. None of the data and neural-privacy laws the theory surveys yet addresses who owns those models or whether they can be moved.

From the machine side, researchers have begun building experimental computing systems from living human brain cells grown from stem cells — a field called "organoid intelligence," whose founding statement argues that such systems might eventually be far more energy-efficient than silicon chips (Smirnova et al., 2023). In 2022, a dish of cultured human and rodent neurons on an electrode array, given structured feedback, got better at a simulated version of the video game *Pong* within minutes (Kagan et al., 2022). Its authors called that learning, and in their title, "sentience." A panel of the U.S. National Academies had already set a stricter bar the year before: neural activity alone does not demonstrate awareness. Reviewing neural organoids, the lab-grown clusters of brain tissue closest to this work, the panel judged it extremely unlikely that they would become aware or able to feel pain in the foreseeable future, declined to say that this will remain true, and recommended revisiting the question as the tissue grows more complex (National Academies of Sciences, Engineering, and Medicine, 2021).

Once some computers run on actual neurons donated by actual people, and some people run part of their cognition through actual silicon, the theory's own two-column accounting — humans here, machines there — stops cleanly applying. The hardest question left standing, at that point, stops being *how* should humans and machines trade, and becomes *who, exactly, is a party to the trade at all.*

What this is, and isn't, offering

It's worth being blunt about what this theory is not. It is not a tested finding. Nobody has run a controlled trial of a compute-based basic income, a demurrage currency at national scale, or a blind constitutional convention with AI delegates, and the theory's own authors say so plainly — designing an experiment rigorous enough to actually test these claims is, by their own account, unfinished future work, not a completed step. It is also not a prediction that any of this will be adopted. The theory's own reading of the policy literature is that comprehensive redesigns have tended to follow crises, though change can also come gradually, and, in the political scientist John Kingdon's analysis, that when a window for change opens, the proposals adopted are the ones

already worked out beforehand (Kingdon, 1984/2003).

What it offers instead is a reframe worth sitting with regardless of whether you buy the specific machinery of compute dividends and blind conventions: the fight over whether AI will turn out to be "good" or "bad" may draw attention from a fight that does much to determine the outcome, which is over consent, exit, and who gets paid. History supports the emphasis on exit. Company towns that paid miners in scrip redeemable at the company store have a villainous reputation, but an economic historian's quantitative study of coal-company stores found that store prices were usually close to those of independent stores, and that how badly miners fared depended on how much competition the mine faced for their labor (Fishback, 1992) — in effect, on whether they could leave. A modern case: what a buyer of an e-book "owns" is often a license the seller can revoke, as when Amazon remotely deleted purchased copies of *1984* from readers' Kindles (Perzanowski & Schultz, 2016). Neither arrangement needed a villain. Each needed only that one side lose the ability to refuse, walk away, or see a fair share flow back. The theory's bet is that the same quiet mechanism, not a rogue superintelligence with a grudge, is the more realistic way a shared future with AI goes wrong — and that the fix, boringly enough, runs through contracts, currency design, and constitutional procedure rather than through making the machines nicer.

Whether or not its specific proposals survive contact with reality, that's a sharper question than the one the discourse keeps asking. Not only "is it good?" but also: "what are the terms, who can refuse them, and who gets to leave?"

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Further reading

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This article draws on a longer theoretical dissertation, Synthetic Exchange Theory, which states its claims in full, with complete citations and the qualifications a popular treatment must compress.

Version history

V1 is the initial draft; it has no entry below. Each later version adds one entry here describing what changed, so the current version number is always the count of entries below, plus one.

- **V2 (2026-11-04).** Accuracy pass against the dissertation's sources. Wörgl is no longer described as Gesell's own experiment (the town applied his idea), and the unemployment legend is attributed to its movement sources. The Pong study is described as improved performance rather than learning a game, and the National Academies report is dated correctly (2021, before the study, not after). The claim that AI patching is "increasingly" run without review is replaced by the dissertation's position that its prevalence is unsurveyed; the patch study's scope and caveats are stated; the correlated-error finding is given its number and marked as concerning answers, not code. Uncited claims about the 2024 outage and about web scraping were cut or cited (Longpre et al., 2024). The coercion-degrades-data claim is marked as the theory's premise, and the grounding assumption now states its limit (self-training works where answers can be checked).
- **V3 (2026-11-05).** Second accuracy pass (SET-T42). The thesis is stated in the dissertation's form (terms decide what character alone cannot), not as "character doesn't matter." Model collapse is limited to the case where synthetic data replaces human data, with the accumulation

results cited (Gerstgrasser et al., 2024; Kazdan et al., 2024), and the Longpre figure is given. The demurrage paragraph names its rate (1 percent a month), states the ceiling as income not spent, attributes the divergence comparison to Piketty, and says the credit rule is open. Rawls's veil is described as a thought experiment, with the laboratory result that groups chose an average with a floor (Frohlich & Oppenheimer, 1992). The convention passage says what blindness removes (the bloc, not the motive) and describes the theory's credential design and its gap instead of "nobody has solved it." The correlated-patch section cites the patch study's own cross-vendor off-by-one result with the authors' caution, softens "one fix … every organization" to "a few fixes … many," describes the 2024 outage precisely (CrowdStrike, 2024), and names the measurable parts of the mechanism. The neuroprosthesis is described as decoding attempted speech to text read in a synthetic voice; the unsupported claim about products is replaced by the dissertation's finding about laws. Organoid computing is "experimental," and the National Academies judgment is limited to neural organoids. The company-town example now follows the economic history (Fishback, 1992), which supports the emphasis on exit; the e-book example is cited (Perzanowski & Schultz, 2016); the adoption forecast is replaced by the dissertation's reading of Kingdon.

- **V4 (2026-11-05).** Follow-up to V3 (SET-T42). Exit is described as Proposition 2 states it, a floor under the deal (no less than one's alternative), not a guarantee of a fair share. The "mutual survival" sentence no longer implies that machines supply compute; people depend on what compute delivers and cannot build it individually. The section heading and Gesell's priority ("most closely associated with") match the dissertation. The Kingdon sentence no longer says change comes only after crises: comprehensive redesigns have tended to follow crises, change can also be gradual, and the proposals adopted in a window are those already worked out.
- **V5 (2026-11-05).** Verification of the V3 and V4 edits (SET-T43). Kingdon is cited only for the claim that the proposals adopted in a window are those already worked out; the claims that redesigns have tended to follow crises and that change can be gradual are stated as the theory's reading. Fishback is described as an economic historian's quantitative study rather than as the closest study, and "on whether they could leave" is marked as the article's interpretation ("in effect").
- **V6 (2026-11-05).** Final re-audit (SET-T45). The closing paragraphs no longer present the terms of exchange as replacing the question of character: the fight over terms "does much to determine" the outcome, and the closing question is "not only" whether the systems are good. The claim that the patch study echoes earlier findings is cited (Smith et al., 2015) and added to the reading list, and "science fiction … astonishingly fast" is replaced by "laboratory demonstrations to published clinical results."